

CASE STUDY REPORT

The Therac-25 Radiation Therapy Accidents



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Course Name: Professional Ethics

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Date of Submission: 16-10-2025

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1. Executive Summary

This report examines the **Therac-25 radiation therapy accidents**, one of the most significant ethical failures in medical technology history. Developed by Atomic Energy of Canada Limited (AECL), the machine's software replaced crucial hardware safety systems, resulting in at least six massive radiation overdoses between 1985 and 1987.

KEY ETHICAL ISSUES:

The case exposes grave **ethical lapses**:

- Overconfidence in software
- Inadequate testing
- Poor regulatory oversight
- Prioritization of reputation over transparency

It underscores how professional responsibility and engineering ethics must align to safeguard human life.

2. Introduction

Background of the machine (Therac-25):

The **Therac-25** was a computer-controlled linear accelerator introduced in 1982 by AECL for cancer radiation therapy. It promised greater precision and automation through a software-driven control system. However, design shortcuts and insufficient testing transformed innovation into catastrophe.

Context of the Case:

Between 1985 and 1987, hospitals across the United States and Canada reported mysterious radiation overdoses. Investigations revealed that AECL had eliminated hardware interlocks—relying solely on software to prevent excessive radiation exposure.

Objective:

This report aims to analyze the ethical violations that led to these failures, evaluate them through ethical theories, and recommend preventive measures for future professional practice.

3. Case Description

The Therac-25 was installed in 11 hospitals across North America and, unlike its predecessors, relied entirely on software to control beam intensity and positioning. Between 1985 and 1987, several patients suffered massive overdoses of radiation due to software errors, leading to at least six confirmed deaths and numerous serious injuries. Investigations revealed that the system lacked adequate safety interlocks and proper software testing, highlighting critical flaws in relying solely on software for life-critical operations. This case became a landmark example in discussions of software safety and medical device regulation.

Chronology of Events:

- **1985–1987:** Six patients received massive radiation overdoses, leading to serious injury or death.
- **Operator confusion:** The machine's interface provided no clear indication of malfunctions.
- **AECL response:** The company initially denied responsibility, attributing accidents to operator error.
- **Regulatory action:** Only after repeated incidents did agencies such as the **U.S. FDA** and **Health Canada** intervene, forcing recalls and safety redesigns.

Key Stakeholders:

- **Patients:** Victims who suffered or died due to overdoses.
- **Operators/Technicians:** Faced unclear controls and insufficient training.
- **AECL Engineers and Management:** Responsible for design, testing, and corrective measures.
- **Regulators:** Tasked with ensuring device safety and approving medical technologies.
- **Public and Medical Institutions:** Lost confidence in automated medical systems.

4. Identification of Ethical Issues

1. **Overconfidence in Software:** AECL engineers assumed their code was infallible, ignoring standard fail-safe requirements.
2. **Negligent Engineering Practices:** Inadequate documentation, testing, and peer review violated professional standards.
3. **Lack of Transparency:** The company delayed reporting known incidents to maintain its reputation.
4. **Regulatory Failure:** Oversight bodies failed to enforce adequate software safety certification.
5. **Accountability Ambiguity:** Engineers, managers, and regulators each deflected responsibility, leaving victims without justice.

5. Analysis

According to Ethical theories and principles,

Utilitarianism

From a utilitarian perspective, AECL failed to achieve the greatest good for the greatest number. The company's actions resulted in avoidable loss of life and public trust—outcomes clearly worse than the minor costs of delay or redesign.

Deontological Ethics

Duty-based ethics emphasize adherence to professional and moral obligations. AECL violated its duty to ensure safety, transparency, and truthfulness, betraying the principle of do no harm central to healthcare technology.

Virtue Ethics

The case reveals a deficiency in virtues such as integrity, humility, and accountability. Engineers and executives prioritized ambition and corporate image over ethical conduct.

Professional Ethics

By removing safety interlocks and neglecting formal verification, AECL breached engineering standards of care and the codes of ethics outlined by professional bodies like IEEE and ACM.

Stakeholder Decisions

- The manufacturer relied solely on software for safety, bypassing hardware interlocks and thorough testing.
- Hospital administrators implemented the machine without fully assessing risks or ensuring proper staff training.
- Regulatory bodies approved the device with limited scrutiny of software safety and operational hazards.

Possible Alternatives

- Implement rigorous software validation and testing before deployment.
- Include redundant hardware safety interlocks to prevent overdoses.
- Provide comprehensive training for hospital staff on safe operation.
- Delay deployment until safety concerns were fully addressed.

Consequences

- Patients suffered radiation overdoses, leading to deaths and severe injuries.
- Hospitals faced legal challenges, reputational damage, and loss of public trust.
- The company experienced regulatory scrutiny, ethical condemnation, and long-term damage to credibility.
- Society at large lost confidence in medical technology and highlighted the need for stricter safety regulations.

6. Recommendations / Solutions

1. **Hybrid Safety Systems:** Always retain hardware interlocks as secondary protection alongside software controls.
2. **Independent Testing:** Subject safety-critical software to rigorous, third-party verification.
3. **Incident Reporting Protocols:** Mandate transparent disclosure of all device failures.

4. **User-Centered Design:** Provide intuitive interfaces and operator training to minimize human error.
5. **Regulatory Strengthening:** Enforce stricter software safety certification and periodic audits.
6. **Ethics Education:** Embed ethics and risk awareness into engineering and software curricula.

7. Conclusion

The **Therac-25** disaster remains a cornerstone case in engineering ethics, illustrating that innovation without accountability can have fatal consequences. The tragedy catalyzed reform in **medical device safety, software engineering standards, and regulatory frameworks** worldwide.

For professionals, it serves as a lasting reminder: **technical excellence must always be guided by moral responsibility.**

8. References

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